Model AI Use Policy for a Youth-Serving Nonprofit

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A draft policy that keeps children's information out of unapproved AI tools and keeps staff, not software, in charge of decisions about people.

> This is a model draft, adapted from one written for Big Brothers Big Sisters of the Greater Sacramento Area. As of November 2026 that organization has not decided whether to adopt it, and no organization has adopted it.

The first rule

A small youth-serving nonprofit can use AI to write, code and answer routine questions, so the first policy question is what staff may put into it. This model answers with one rule: identifying information about children and families never enters an AI tool that has not been approved for it. A second rule follows from the first: AI assists, and staff decide.

Four data tiers

Tier	Examples	AI rule
1 Restricted	Names, contact details, addresses and birth dates of youth and guardians; background-check results; safety reports; interview and match notes	Never in an unapproved tool. Reaches an AI feature only masked, and only after a High-rated review.
2 Confidential	Volunteer application details, donor records, unpublished budgets, personnel matters	Approved tools whose terms bar training on the organization's inputs.
3 Internal	Procedures, templates, agendas	Approved tools; general tools only with no Tier 1 or 2 content.
4 Public	Published web text, press releases	Any tool.

Masking means removing names, addresses, contact details and birth dates, and anything else that identifies a child or family, before text leaves the organization's own system.

Approved and prohibited uses

No AI tool decides whether a child is safe, a volunteer is eligible, or two people are matched.

Approved, with human review: drafting text from Tier 3 or 4 content; summarizing published research for grant narratives, with every claim checked against its source; brainstorming activities and outreach wording; coding help using synthetic or masked data; formatting spreadsheets that hold Tier 3 or 4 data only.

Prohibited: entering Tier 1 data into any tool not approved for it; using AI to screen, rank, score or recommend decisions about volunteers, families or matches; sending AI-written messages to families without staff review; uploading photos, voice or video of children; presenting unchecked AI output to a funder as fact; using personal AI accounts for anything above Tier 4.

Approval before any new tool

Before adopting a tool, switching on an AI feature, or finding a new use for an approved tool, the requester answers five questions and the policy owner rates the risk.

1. What will it be used for, and what do staff do today without it?
2. Which data tiers will it see, and which fields?
3. Does the vendor train on the organization's inputs, and how long does it keep them? Answer from the vendor's published terms.
4. Does output reach a child, family or volunteer, or influence a decision about one?
5. What human check sits between the output and any action?

Rating	Trigger	Approver
Low	Tier 3 or 4 data only; output stays with staff	One staff member
Medium	Tier 2 data, or output goes to families after staff review	Policy owner
High	Any Tier 1 data, or any influence on a decision about a person	Executive director, in writing

Roles, review and incidents

A named policy owner keeps the tool inventory, runs intake, and logs every decision, including rejections. The executive director approves High-rated uses. Whoever sends AI-drafted text to a family, volunteer or funder reads it and owns it. Mistakes go to the policy owner within one business day, and the policy is reviewed every six months and whenever a tool or a law changes.

Staff get a short training at onboarding and at each review. When Tier 1 data reaches an unapproved tool, the policy owner logs it, contains it (delete the entry if the vendor allows, revoke access, stop the use) and tells the executive director. A tool that fails review is not adopted, and one that later fails is retired. Anyone who builds or configures a system checks that its masking works before each release.

Alignment with the NIST AI RMF

The NIST AI Risk Management Framework 1.0 (January 2023) is voluntary and has no certification, so this table shows alignment, not conformance.

NIST function	Where the policy answers it
Govern	Named owner, approval levels, training, vendor questions
Map	Tool inventory, intended-use and impact questions, data tiers
Measure	Review dates, incident log, checks on masking before each release
Manage	Prohibited uses, human review, incident steps, retiring tools

Limits

This is a model draft. No organization has adopted it, counsel has not reviewed it, and it has not been tested in practice, so it does not by itself satisfy any law or contract. A real adoption needs a completed tool inventory, vendor terms checked tool by tool, and legal review of breach-notification and child-safety duties.